# Our Children (2)

### All Are Able To Choose What They Become

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In a series of articles on children in one of Sydney's Sunday newspapers, the story was told of the extraordinarily disadvantaged life and background of a 9 year old boy who, until he was taken into care by welfare officers, had spent the whole of his young life begging and stealing, generally scrounging an existence in the dirty alleys of some of the inner city slum areas. It was said his unmarried mother, an alcoholic, had rarely clothed, bathed or fed the boy, and at the beginning, he had spat at, kicked and punched people who tried to help him. In time, the scars of his early experiences as a child should fade, though we know they will never go away. An enormous amount of damage had been done.

Similar stories have appeared in other articles. But this one highlights a problem which may have occurred to you if you read my previous talk. I had been talking about parental responsibility to children; a responsibility which covers not just their well being so far as this world is concerned, but which also must take in spiritual goals and objectives for them. Life in this world is far from being the thing that matters most of all as we at times imagine it to be. Success and prosperity are not the important things they are made out to be. In fact comparatively, they are very unimportant.

What really matters and what is really important is that through and by means of all the different experiences that come to us here - the challenges and opportunities, the joys and disappointments - we should come to choose the Lord's way and prepare ourselves for life in heaven when we die. If we do this, even though we live obscurely and never make the pages of the newspapers, we shall have fulfilled the purpose of our life in this world. We shall have accomplished the most important thing of all. 'Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.' Matthew 6:19-21. Clearly what the Lord is saying is that our emphasis is to be on the things of the spirit and on acquiring spiritual qualities. And as it is with ourselves in our own approach to life, so it also is to be the guiding principle where our dealings with our children are concerned.

As adults they will take over responsibility for their spiritual welfare and destiny. Whether they regenerate and overcome the loves of self and of the world inclinations to which we all possess, is up to them. But in the years before they take over that responsibility, while they are children and still under the care and influence of their parents, a great deal can be done to set them in the right direction. With parents a choice is involved. We can either cooperate with the Lord who is wanting to lead our children to the life of heaven, or we can decline to do so, and by our emphasis on success and 'getting on', place obstacles in the way and make things more difficult for them. What we have to realise is that whilst they can be broken and changed, the patterns and general direction of adult attitudes are set in childhood. A big responsibility falls on parents to ensure as far as possible that these are as we would truly want them to be.

However this raises the problem I mentioned earlier and which is highlighted by a story of disadvantaged childhood like the one I told right at the beginning. Granted that childhood experiences and influences at that time do have a deep impact on us, doesn't this mean that some children are bound to be at a disadvantage where regeneration is concerned? Scarred as they will be by experiences that have come to them in their earliest years, and twisted in their thinking as they can become, what of their chances in adulthood to regenerate? To shed the attitudes and ways to which they were introduced as children through parental neglect, irresponsibility or sheer stupidity, or for some other reason.

The most important thing to remember here is that the Lord only ever asks of us as adults that we live according to the concepts of right and wrong, of good and evil, which have been instilled in us. And everyone has some notion of these. It may not be much, but even in the situations of disadvantaged childhood such as we have referred to, something is known of the difference between right and wrong, good and evil; and the opportunity for deciding between the two is there. Whether it is much or whether it is little, we are called upon (by the Lord) to decide within the content of what we know and have been taught. Even the child of the slums when an adult has a choice and his eventual destiny, either in heaven or in hell, is in his hands.

Therefore we reject the notion that a person is simply a product of his or her environment and nothing more. Without question, environment has a massive impact on a child. And what is also without question is that a great deal of harm can be done by way of that environment in which a child is brought up. We have said this. But far from being the helpless victims of the forces that bear upon them, children once they are adults, have the God given ability to react variously to the influences which surround them and to select what they want to be ... the kind of person they want to be... the particular qualities which

they want to embody in their lives. It is very easy to blame childhood experiences and influences, habits and attitudes which we acknowledge we possess. We may know we are miserly, for example, but that's the way we were brought up, we say. But we can choose to be otherwise. It's up to us. Perhaps the truth of the matter is that we just don't want to be different. We enjoy being miserly just as our parents were.

Were it not for the fact that every one of us is able to select from the influences that reach us, or which reached us as children; that in fact we are able to choose what our state of life will be; we would be ascribing to the Lord a kind of determinism. And that is just not on. In every situation the opportunity to choose is there.

With few exceptions every parent loves their child and is moved to provide for them, to protect them and make what are sometimes quite enormous sacrifices for them. But though this is so the love of children differs with parents according to their own quality and state of life. If the parents are unregenerate then their love of children must have a lot of that quality about it. In such cases the children easily become an extension of the parents. They enjoy their accomplishments and are personally flattered by them. And this is something every parent has to guard against. So often the love of self can creep into things. "My little Johnny has done this", "My little Johnny has done that". And from the sidelines of the football field we urge a starring performance from our child so that if others don't congratulate us we can certainly congratulate ourselves.

So often the love of the world can also creep into things. "I want you son, to grow up and became rich and successful". Not necessarily said but often thought. And then there is as well, the love of dominating which also needs to be guarded against. Forcing our will on our children. Putting our children down. Unjustly criticising their efforts. Belittling them. All of this arises from the love of dominating. However if the parents are themselves endeavouring to become regenerate, things will be a whole lot different, though they will not avoid the intrusion of these loves into their approach and attitudes.

Swedenborg wrote of the love of children that it can be either 'natural' or 'spiritual'. It can, in other words, spring from the love of self or the love of the Lord. 'The nature of the love of little children and love of older children found in spiritual people, and the nature of it in natural ones, is clearly apparent from such people after death. For on arriving in the other world, most fathers remember their children who have passed on before them; and these are presented to them, and they recognize each other. Spiritual fathers simply look them over and ask them in what state they are, rejoicing if all is well with them, and grieving if it is not. Then following some conversation, instruction and counsel regarding a heavenly moral life, they part from them.

'In contrast, as soon as natural fathers notice that they are living after death and recall to mind the children who have passed on before them, and in accordance with their wish and prayer these are also presented to them, they immediately throw their arms around each other and cling to each other like bound bundles of sticks. Moreover, the father then takes continual delight in beholding them and talking with them. If the father is told that some of these children of his are satanic fiends, and that they have inflicted injuries on the good, he nevertheless keeps them in a cluster about him.' Conjugial Love' 406.

Granted this is so in the spiritual world, but at the same time it confronts us with two completely different approaches to our children. And we must decide what ours is going to be.

'Which of you, if your son asks for bread, will give him a stone? Or if he asks for a fish, will give him a snake?' Matthew 7:9. We say we wouldn't. Of course we wouldn't. Whatever our children wanted we would try to give it to them.

But we miss the point. Our children unconsciously look to us for their goals and ideals and receive from us their loves and affections. This is what is meant by them asking for bread. And what do we give them? That's the question. What do we give them? They look to us for bread but so often they receive a stone. They also come to us for a knowledge of spiritual things which is what is meant by them asking for a fish. And again, what do they receive? The danger is that it will be nothing other than an encouragement to trust only in themselves and in their own experiences of life. A snake instead of a fish.